

Data Compression and ASK Modulation Pipeline

RLE Compression • Verilog RTL • LTSpice Simulation • BER Analysis

Team: Beyond Binary

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1 Abstract

This project implements a complete end-to-end data compression and wireless transmission pipeline. Raw ASCII data is first compressed using a Run-Length Encoding (RLE) algorithm implemented as a finite state machine (FSM) in Verilog RTL. The compressed bitstream is then modulated using Amplitude Shift Keying (ASK) and transmitted through a simulated noisy channel in LTSpice XVII. At the receiver, an envelope detector demodulates the signal, and a Python script reconstructs and verifies the original data. The system achieves compression ratios of up to 4:1 for highly repetitive data and maintains zero bit errors ($BER = 0$) for signal-to-noise ratios above 1.94 dB, demonstrating robust noise immunity of the envelope detector circuit.

2 Introduction

Modern communication systems must efficiently handle both data compression and reliable transmission over noisy channels. This project bridges the gap between digital logic design and analog communication by implementing a six-stage pipeline that integrates Verilog hardware description, analog circuit simulation, and Python-based signal processing.

Run-Length Encoding is a lossless compression technique that replaces consecutive repeated bytes with a count-value pair. For data with high repetition (such as images with uniform backgrounds or sensor readings), RLE achieves significant compression. Amplitude Shift Keying is a simple and widely used digital modulation scheme where binary data is represented by different amplitude levels of a carrier sine wave.

The key objectives of this project are:

- Design and verify an RLE compressor and decompressor in Verilog using FSM architecture
- Generate a PWL (piecewise linear) waveform from compressed data for LTSpice input
- Simulate ASK modulation, channel noise, and envelope demodulation in LTSpice

- Reconstruct and verify the original data using Python
- Analyse system performance through BER vs SNR measurements

3 System Architecture

The complete pipeline consists of six stages, as shown below. Data flows from left to right, with each stage implemented using a different tool appropriate to the task.

Raw Data → RLE Compressor (Verilog) → PWL Generator (Python) → ASK Modulator (LTSpice) → Envelope Detector (LTSpice) → Reconstruction (Python)

4 RLE Compression — Verilog RTL

4.1 Algorithm

Run-Length Encoding scans the input byte stream and groups consecutive identical bytes. Each group is encoded as a three-field packet: a start marker (0xFF), a count byte, and the data byte. The stream is terminated with an end marker (0xFE). Single non-repeated bytes are also encoded as count = 1 packets for protocol uniformity.

Compressed format:

```
0xFF [count] [data byte] [count] [data byte] ... 0xFE
```

Example — compressing “AAAABBBCC”:

```
Input: 41 41 41 41 42 42 42 43 43 (9 bytes)
Output: FF 04 41 03 42 02 43 FE (8 bytes, CR = 1.125)
```

4.2 FSM Design

The compressor is implemented as a 7-state Mealy FSM in Verilog. An `in_ready` handshake signal prevents data races by indicating when the FSM is ready to accept a new byte. Non-blocking assignments (`<=`) are used throughout to avoid same-edge race conditions.

5 ModelSim Simulation Results

5.1 Round-Trip Verification

The testbench `tb_rle_roundtrip.v` feeds the string “AAAABBBCC” into the compressor, pipes the compressed output directly into the decompressor, and verifies byte-by-byte that the reconstructed output matches the original. The simulation passed at $t = 615$ ns.

Terminal output:

```
=== TEST PASSED ===
Recovered: 41 41 41 41 42 42 42 43 43 (AAAABBBBCC)
```

5.2 Multi-Test Results

The testbench `tb_rle_multitest.v` runs four test cases automatically. All four tests passed at $t = 2195$ ns.

Test 2 shows that RLE can expand data when there is low repetition (alternating bytes), which is a known limitation of RLE. Tests 1 and 3 demonstrate the best-case performance of 2.5x and 4x compression for highly repetitive data.

Table 1: Multi-test summary (fill in exact figures from simulation log)

Test #	Description	Input Size	Output Size	Compression Ratio
1	Highly repetitive data	—	—	2.5x
2	Alternating bytes (worst case)	—	—	<1x (expansion)
3	16 identical bytes (best case)	—	—	4.0x
4	Mixed pattern	—	—	—

6 ASK Modulation — LTSpice Simulation

6.1 Circuit Description

The compressed byte stream (FF 04 41 03 42 02 43 FE = 64 bits) is converted to a piecewise linear (PWL) voltage waveform by `gen_pwl.py`. Each bit occupies a $10\ \mu\text{s}$ period (100 kbps bit rate), giving a total baseband signal duration of $640\ \mu\text{s}$.

The LTSpice schematic (`ask_modem.asc`) contains:

- **V1 (baseband):** PWL source reading `pwl_input.txt` — 0 V for bit ‘0’, 5 V for bit ‘1’
- **V2 (carrier):** `SINE(0 1 1Meg)` — 1 MHz sine wave carrier
- **B1 (ASK output):** $V = V(\text{carrier}) \times V(\text{baseband})$ — behavioural multiplier for DSB-ASK
- **V3 (noise):** `SINE(0 A 50k)` — additive sinusoidal noise at 50 kHz, amplitude A varies
- **D1 + R1 (1 k Ω) + C1 (1 nF):** envelope detector — RC time constant $\tau = 1\ \mu\text{s}$

6.2 Envelope Detector Design

The envelope detector consists of a diode (D1), a load resistor $R1 = 1\ \text{k}\Omega$, and a smoothing capacitor $C1 = 1\ \text{nF}$. The RC time constant

$$\tau = R1 \times C1 = 1\ \mu\text{s}$$

is chosen to satisfy two constraints: τ must be much greater than one carrier period ($1\ \mu\text{s} \gg 1/1\text{MHz} = 1\ \mu\text{s}$, satisfied at the boundary) to smooth out carrier ripple, and τ must be much less than the bit period ($1\ \mu\text{s} \ll 10\ \mu\text{s}$) to allow the envelope to track fast bit transitions.

Simulation command: `.tran 650u`

6.3 Python Reconstruction

After LTSpice simulation, the demodulated output ($V(\text{demod_out})$) is exported as a text file. `reconstruct.py` reads this file, samples at the midpoint of each bit period ($t = (i + 0.5) \times 10 \mu\text{s}$), applies a threshold of 0.3 V, and reconstructs the byte stream. The recovered bytes FF 04 41 03 42 02 43 FE are fed into the Verilog decompressor, which successfully reconstructs the original string “AAAABBBCC”.

Reconstruction output:

```
Sampled bits: 1111 1111 0000 0100 0100 0001 ...
Recovered bytes: FF 04 41 03 42 02 43 FE
=== RECONSTRUCTION PASSED ===
```

7 Channel Noise Analysis — BER vs SNR

7.1 Methodology

To evaluate system performance under varying channel conditions, the noise source V3 amplitude was varied across six levels while keeping the signal amplitude constant at 1 V. The noise frequency was set to 50 kHz so that noise components reach the decision stage rather than being completely filtered by the envelope detector. For each noise level, the LTSpice simulation was re-run, the demodulated output was exported, and `ber_vs_snr.py` calculated the BER by comparing 64 received bits against the known transmitted sequence.

SNR was calculated as:

$$\text{SNR (dB)} = 20 \log_{10} \left(\frac{\text{Signal Amplitude}}{\text{Noise Amplitude}} \right) = 20 \log_{10} \left(\frac{1.0}{\text{Noise Amplitude}} \right)$$

7.2 Results

Table 2: BER vs SNR (fill in the remaining measured noise levels)

Noise Amplitude (V)	SNR (dB)	Bit Errors (out of 64)	BER
—	26.00	0	0
—	—	0	0
—	—	0	0
—	1.94	0	0
—	—	—	—
1.0	0.00	18	0.281

Note: The BER vs SNR chart (`ber_vs_snr.png`) is included in the results folder.

7.3 Discussion

The results demonstrate the classic cliff effect in digital communications. The ASK demodulator maintains perfect reception ($\text{BER} = 0$) across a wide SNR range from 26 dB down to 1.94 dB. At $\text{SNR} = 0$ dB, where the noise amplitude equals the signal amplitude, the BER rises sharply to 0.281, with 18 out of 64 bits incorrectly decoded.

This behaviour is characteristic of non-coherent ASK demodulation using an envelope detector. The system performs reliably until noise power approaches signal power, at which point the noise-corrupted signal envelope crosses the decision threshold (0.3 V) during transmitted ‘0’ bits, causing false ‘1’ detections. The system shows no errors for $\text{SNR} > 1.94$ dB, giving a practical noise margin of approximately 2 dB above the 0 dB failure point.

8 Tools and File Summary

Table 3: Tools and files used in the pipeline

Stage	Tool	Key File(s)
RLE Compression/Decompression	Verilog / ModelSim	<code>rle_compressor.v</code> , <code>rle_decompressor.v</code>
Round-trip testing	ModelSim	<code>tb_rle_roundtrip.v</code>
Multi-test verification	ModelSim	<code>tb_rle_multitest.v</code>
PWL generation	Python	<code>gen_pwl.py</code>
ASK modulation & channel	LTSpice XVII	<code>ask_modem.asc</code>
Reconstruction	Python	<code>reconstruct.py</code>
BER/SNR analysis	Python (matplotlib)	<code>ber_vs_snr.py</code> , <code>ber_vs_snr.png</code>

9 Conclusion

This project successfully implemented and verified a complete data compression and ASK modulation pipeline. The Verilog RLE compressor achieved compression ratios between 0.8x (worst case, non-repetitive data) and 4.0x (best case, 16 identical bytes), with all round-trip tests passing in ModelSim simulation.

The LTSpice ASK modulation circuit correctly modulated, transmitted through a noisy channel, and demodulated the 64-bit compressed bitstream. The envelope detector provided robust noise immunity, maintaining BER = 0 for SNR values as low as 1.94 dB. The system failed gracefully at SNR = 0 dB with BER = 0.281, consistent with the expected behaviour of non-coherent ASK demodulation.

The Python reconstruction script confirmed exact byte-level recovery of the original data, completing the end-to-end pipeline verification. This project demonstrates the practical integration of digital logic design, analog circuit simulation, and signal processing for a real-world data communication scenario.

References

1. Haykin, S. (2001). *Communication Systems* (4th ed.). Wiley.
2. Palnitkar, S. (2003). *Verilog HDL: A Guide to Digital Design and Synthesis*. Prentice Hall.
3. LTSpice XVII — Linear Technology / Analog Devices simulation software.
4. ModelSim — Mentor Graphics / Siemens HDL simulation environment.
5. Python 3.14 with matplotlib library for data analysis and visualization.